The second difference between this book and other works on the subject is that our arguments depart from standard optimist and pessimist offerings in the nuclear proliferation literature. Ganguly's argument shares rational deterrence theory's assumption that the potentially catastrophic costs of conflict promote stability in a nuclear environment. However, he differs from standard optimistic approaches in an important fashion. Virtually all the work on the stability of nuclear deterrence among horizontal proliferators is based on deductive logic and not detailed empirical analysis coupled with a theoretical corpus.[7] The most important work in this vein is that of Kenneth Waltz.[8] Two other important contributions, from Jordan Seng and from David J. Karl, while making compelling arguments about the viability of nuclear deterrence, are not based on careful examination of particular cases. Instead Seng relies mostly on carefully constructed arguments about the structure and disposition of small nuclear forces.[9] Karl, on the other hand, provides a modicum of empirical evidence from South Asia but bases his argument mostly on a critique of the propensity of nuclear pessimists to ascribe the baleful characteristics of the superpower experience with nuclear weapons to emerging nuclear powers.[10]

What distinguishes the present analysis from those of other proliferation optimists is the careful attention that it pays to the particular features of the South Asian political landscape. This work constitutes an attempt to carefully test the central premises of rational deterrence theory against a set of South Asian cases and demonstrate their robustness. In effect, the analysis moves away from largely logical and analytic exploration of the strategic consequences of proliferation and instead seeks to merge both theory and data.

Kapur offers a perspective that he calls strategic pessimism. This approach shares the pessimists' belief that the spread of nuclear weapons can be highly destabilizing. Unlike leading pessimist arguments, however, it does not locate proliferations' primary danger in suboptimal decision-making of the security and military organizations that control nuclear weapons. Rather, strategic pessimism shares optimists' assumption of rational decision-making on the part of new nuclear states and shows that wholly rational